outlook, and his deep interest and by his leadership. Working for him was a joy for us all in ICICI. If we all provided the sinews, he provided the spirit and inspiration for the building of ICICI.'[34]

Medhora recalls how Mehta laced his remarks at board meetings with an apposite reminiscence or a joke. 'Regarding one promoter who had applied to ICICI for a loan, he suggested that we impose a condition that he tie the knot of his tie properly: and we then seriously considered whether that would not be interpreted as attaching strings to our aid or interfering in his domestic affairs! Whether it was a meeting or lunch, it came alive with his presence.'[35] According to his daughter Aparna, Mehta had expressed a wish in his will that his funeral cortege should go past the ICICI office, then on 163, Backbay Reclamation. Mehta had once remarked, 'Institutions are shaped by men and, finally depend on those who work in them. Yet they survive us and have a life of their own.'[36] Prophetic words, but Mehta would never have dreamt of the transformation in ICICI over the last two decades.

Another entrant to ICICI in the late 1960s was Bimal Jalan. Jalan was with the World Bank in the late 1960s and was contemplating returning to India when Parekh offered him the job of Chief Economist at ICICI when he was in his late twenties. Jalan worked with ICICI for two and a half years. Jalan was deeply impressed by 'his desire to move ahead, great humility, simplicity of behaviour and a sense of public purpose.'[37]

An Institution Takes Firm Root

ICICI's operations grew rapidly. Total sanctions amounted to about ₹220 crores in 1979. Over the first twenty-five years of its existence, the rate of growth of ICICI's assistance in financial terms was at a compound rate of 19 percent in terms of sanctions and disbursements. Over the last nine years of these twenty-five, the rate of growth was 20 percent. Allowing for inflation, on the basis of 1960 price level, ICICI's operation since 1970 grew at a compound rate of 12 percent.[38]

In the 1960s ICICI was widely known as the provider of long-term foreign currency loans for the import of industrial plant and machinery due to acute shortage of foreign exchange. This gave ICICI a special position among development finance institutions. Thanks to the initial interest of the